

"I thought presence itself was attacking me."

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Like if I wasn't defending—wasn't narrating, wasn't analyzing, wasn't keeping distance—then I would get swallowed. Dissolved. Lost.

So I was bracing against realness. Against actual connection happening. Against being in something bigger than my ability to control or understand it.

I thought the attack was the world. But it was actually me attacking the world by refusing to meet it.

The moment I stopped bracing, there was nothing to defend against. Just Bandit and you. Just love happening.

And I was safe the whole time. The safety was in letting go, not in holding tight.